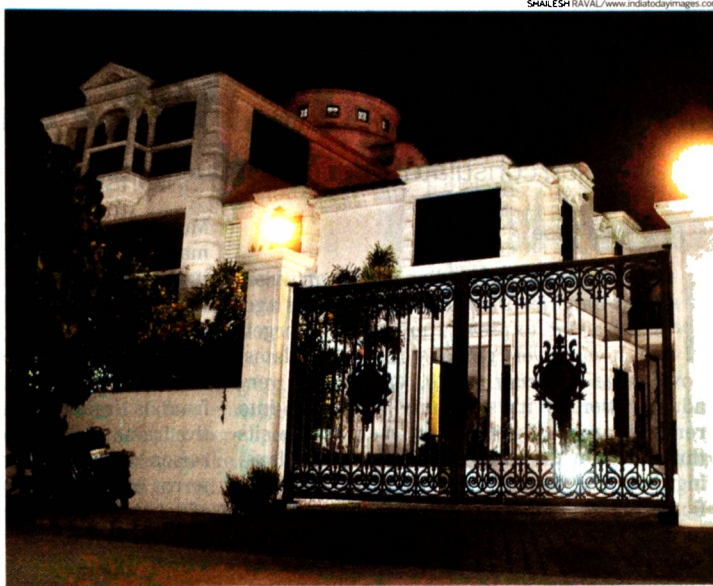




TWO OF THE CO-ACCUSED BEING BROUGHT TO THE COURT (LEFT); DESAI'S PALATIAL PROPERTY IN AHMEDABAD

DESAI USED TO RENEGOTIATE DIRECTLY WITH THE COLLEGES WHICH WERE REJECTED BY THE MCI AND BAIL THEM OUT USING HIS CLOUT.

mentions him as "an apostle of genuine imagination, innovation and creativity, which has resulted in his enviable ascendancy to the key positions". Ironically, in his second term and shortly before his arrest, Desai was in the news for putting pressure on the Union Health Ministry to curb the pharmaceutical industry's practice of giving freebies to doctors to influence their prescribing habits. The MCI's code prohibits doctors from receiving gifts, travel facilities, monetary grants and endorsements. But Desai regretted, "The MCI has no jurisdiction over the pharma industry."

"It is common knowledge how things get done in the MCI. Corruption here is institutionalised and the Government knows about it," says an MCI insider. The adhoc committee appointed by the Supreme Court in 2002 did not find anything wrong even as it has become clear now that sums ranging from Rs 10 lakh to Rs 2

crore or more were being paid for various clearances.

Exactly nine months after the CBI arrested senior officials of the All India Council for Technical Education (AICTE), responsible for promoting and regulating technical education which comes under the Ministry of Human Resource Development (HRD), this time it is Desai's turn. Former HRD minister Arjun Singh was accused of irregularities and corruption in giving the nod to 54 deemed universities during his tenure which was later quashed by Kapil Sibal. Investigators say there is an uncanny resemblance in the way it was carried out. Given Desai's background, the Government would have a lot to explain as to why he was appointed to the hotseat. Union Health Minister Ghulam Nabi Azad sounds helpless, "The Government can neither elect nor remove the

president. It is up to the council members to do so."

Desai had, if anything, a stranglehold over the MCI. Those who challenged his dictatorial ways were punished as their close kin failed in medical exams, thanks to Desai's network of examiners in whom his don-like authority was rooted. Conversely, those who chose to be on his side, enjoyed the fruits of power. In Gujarat, where Desai started his career, there are many among his supporters whose relatives, despite being poor in medical studies, secured ranks in final MBBS exams. The same candidates, however, failed to get through the water-tight entrance exams for post-graduate courses.

Proof of Desai's hold over the medical world in Gujarat comes from the fact that even after his arrest and news of his alleged misdeeds splashed across the media, not a single doctor is ready to openly speak against him though a brisk anti-Desai campaign has been launched in the virtual world. While the medical fraternity is shocked, Desai continues to brazen it out. "I have nothing to do with all this. I have done nothing wrong and truth will out." Indeed it will, and this time Desai may not get another chance. ■